

NEW AVENGER

Compact and robust, the Grumman TBF Avenger became the United States' standard torpedo-bomber from 1943. The Japanese could match neither the quality nor the quantity of the aircraft deployed by the Americans in the later years of the war.



constituted an impressively potent weapon of attack.

From the start of operations in 1944, it was evident that a gulf had opened up between the Americans and Japanese in terms of technology, flying skills, and tactical organization. Early in February, the heavily defended Japanese naval base at Truk was subjected to raids by aircraft from nine American carriers, including a night attack by Avengers using airborne radar to identify their targets. In addition to suffering heavy loss of shipping, the Japanese lost 10 aircraft for every one American airplane shot down – a sign of things to come.

The Japanese were without Admiral Yamamoto, who had himself become a victim of American air power in April 1943 after the decoding of a radio intercept revealed his itinerary for a tour of Japanese forces in the southwest Pacific. Lockheed Lightning P-38 long-range fighters led by Major John Mitchell were sent from Henderson Field on Guadalcanal to take the admiral. Their task was to fly over more than 400 miles (640km) of ocean and intercept a small flight of Japanese aircraft – two Mitsubishi Betty bombers carrying Yamamoto and his staff, and an escort of six Mitsubishi Zeros – without the help of onboard radar or sophisticated navigational instruments. Mitchell found his way by dead-reckoning, using a compass, a watch, and his airspeed indicator. Thanks to his skill, and to Japanese punctuality, the P-38s found their target over the coast of Bougainville, Solomon Islands.

Admiral Yamamoto's aircraft was shot down and crashed in the jungle. The admiral was thus spared from witnessing the destruction of his navy.

Japanese disaster

The Battle of the Philippine Sea in June 1944 was planned by Japanese commanders

as a masterstroke against the US fleet, which was supposed to be trapped between a powerful carrier force and airbases on the Marianas. Japanese aircraft could in theory shuttle back and forth

between the carriers and the island airstrips, hitting the Americans in between. What actually happened is now known as the "Marianas Turkey Shoot."

Between 8:30am and 3:00pm on June 19, four waves of Japanese aircraft were sent in to attack the US fleet. Fed early warning of the enemy's approach by radar operators, shipborne Combat Information Centers scrambled their fighters and vectored them on to the incoming targets. With no element of surprise, the largely inexperienced Japanese pilots were pounced on by the Hellcats. Any that slipped through were cut down by naval gunners. Meanwhile American bombers attacked the island airfields, and their fighters preyed on Japanese aircraft trying to land there. In all, the Japanese lost over 300 aircraft in the day's fighting, while two Japanese carriers were sunk by American submarines.

Admiral Marc Mitscher, commander of Fast Carrier Task Force 58, felt that the victory would be incomplete without a counterstrike against the Japanese fleet. The enemy was located late in the afternoon of June 20. Mitscher decided to strike immediately, although it would take his aircraft to the extreme limit of their range and they would not be back before nightfall. Over 200 carrier aircraft set off, the usual mix of torpedo-bombers, dive-bombers, and fighters. Watching their fuel levels dropping on the way out, pilots were keenly aware of the

problem they were going to have getting back.

It was evening by the time the Japanese fleet was found and attacked. Lieutenant Don Lewis, flying a Dauntless, recalled the end of his dive from 15,000ft (4,500m) toward a Japanese carrier: "The last time I glanced at my altimeter it registered 3,000ft [900m]. Stopped below, the big carrier looked even larger. It was completely enveloped in a sort of smoke haze. It was hard to stay in my dive this long. Under some conditions, a person can live a lifetime in a few seconds. It was time. I couldn't go any lower. Now! I pulled my bomb release, felt the bomb go away, started my pullout. My eyes watered, my ears hurt, and my altimeter indicated 1,500ft [450m]... I had already closed my dive flaps and had 280 knots, but I couldn't seem to go fast enough... Everywhere I looked there seemed to be ships with every gun blazing. The sky was just a mass of black and white puffs, and in the midst of it, planes already hit, burning and crashing into the water below..."

**JAPANESE MASTERMIND**

Admiral Yamamoto, the man who planned the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, was shot down by the Americans in 1943.

"Our pilots... were improving every day, and the Japanese fleet was not capable of countering our fleet again."

VICE-ADMIRAL WILLIAM I. MARTIN
DISCUSSING THE LAST YEAR OF THE WAR